ELIMINATION PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; remember that it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular elimination play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

There are four or five stages shown for each Deal.

You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

ELIMINATION PLAYS SUMMARY

There are a lot of card combinations in Bridge in which you will be better off if the opponents make the first play in a suit than you would be if you must play it first. Here are three examples.

♦ K 10 3	♦ J 7 3	♦ K 10 3
♦ A J 7	♦ Q 5 2	♦ A 9 7

The first is the frequently occurring two-way finesse. If you play this yourself you have to guess which defender holds the Queen. If the defenders start the suit you automatically win all three tricks.

In the second example you'd like to win one trick, and it will be hard to do if you must start the suit. Perhaps one defender holds both the high honors and you can guess which one and lead through him. Or perhaps someone has a doubleton honor that you can deduce. But if the defenders break the suit you just play second-hand-low and can't miss winning one trick.

With the third example you have almost no chance of three tricks if you start. If they start the suit you play second-hand-low and the next defender must play an honor. You win and then finesse the other defender for the other honor, winning all three tricks when their two honors are divided.

These are only three of many combinations that will benefit you if you can force the defenders to start the suit.
And that is what Elimination plays do; force the defenders to play a particular suit for you.

It works like this. You **strip** the defenders of all their "safe" exit suits, then you **throw-in** one of the defenders. If he has no safe exit, he will have to play a suit that will benefit you, perhaps one of the combinations above.

You will find that most elimination plays occur in suit contracts. This is because you can often pull all the defender's trumps while retaining at least one in both your hand and dummy. Then when the throw-in occurs the defense cannot play a suit of which you and dummy are both void because of the threat of a ruff and sluff.

25 examples are probably worth more than 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



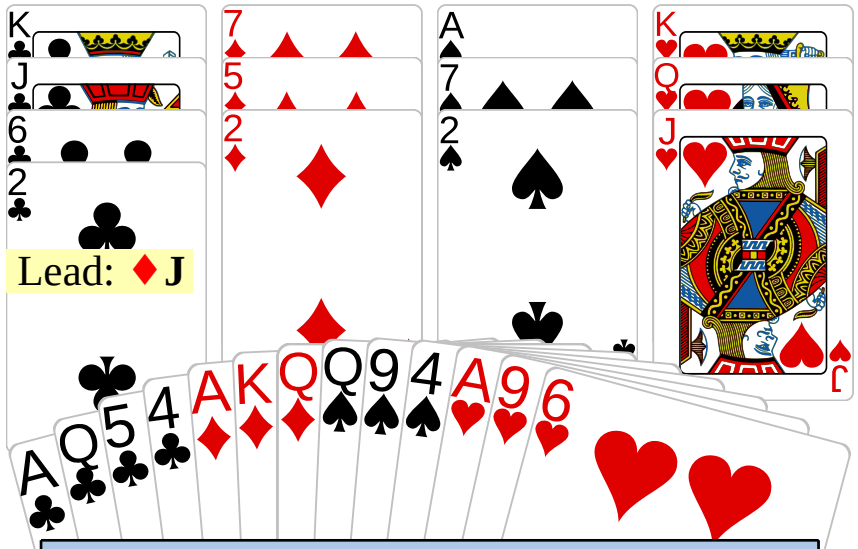
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



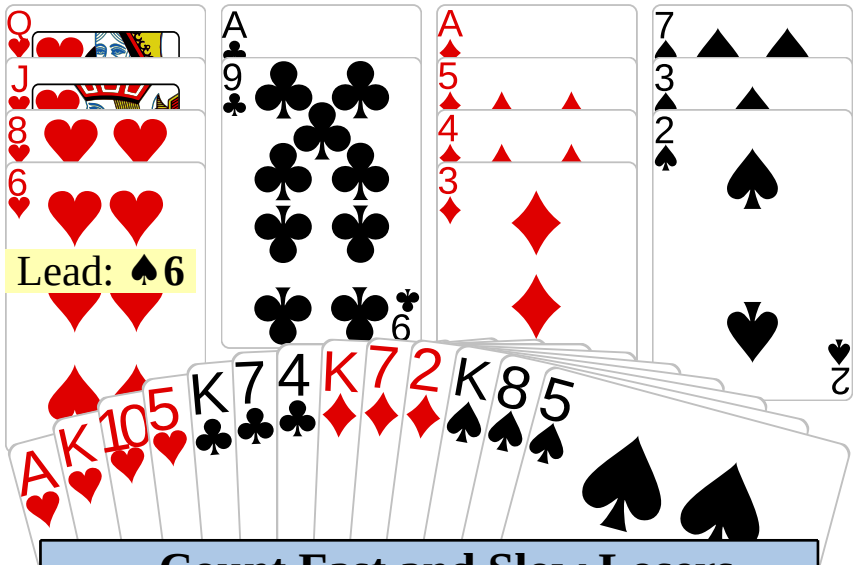
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **6NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



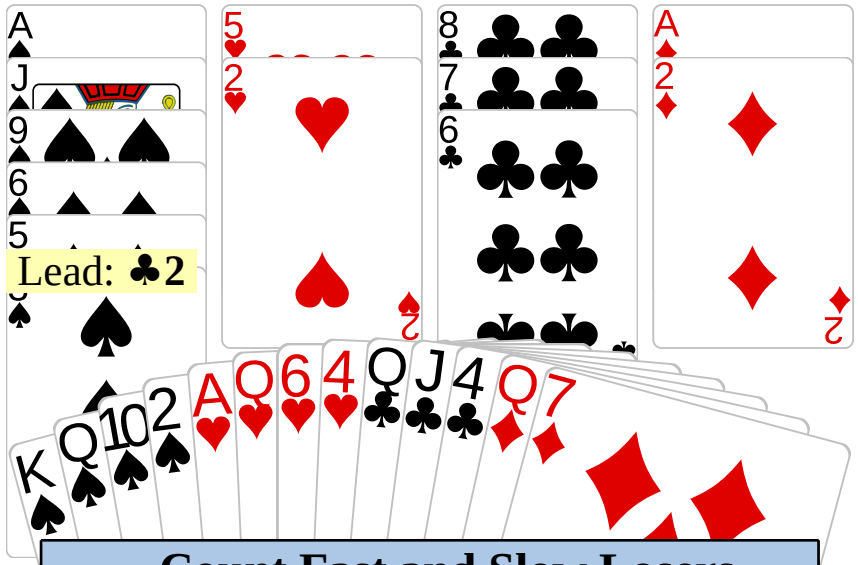
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 6 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣K

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠5

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦J

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠6

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣2

Board 1
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 6 ♥ A K J 10 5 2 ♦ K 5 3 ♣ A 10	
♠ J 10 2 ♥ 9 8 3 ♦ J 10 4 ♣ 9 6 4 2	N W E S	♠ Q 9 7 4 ♥ 6 ♦ A Q 8 ♣ K Q J 7 5
	♠ A 8 5 3 ♥ Q 7 4 ♦ 9 7 6 2 ♣ 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♣	Pass
Pass	Dbl	Pass	1♠
Pass	3♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♣K

South realizes that to make a takeout double, then jump in your own suit you must have a very good hand. So he bids the game. North plays 4♥. East leads the ♣K, which you take with the ♣A.

You have four losers. If you are thinking about leading toward your ♦K you are delusionary. East has the ♦A and you know it. Your best hope is to end-play East with the ♣10 and force him to break the ♦s.

Play one round of trumps with the ♥A. You can't play any more because you will need an entry to dummy for the elimination.

Next play ♠K, ♠A and ruff a ♠ high.

Lead a ♥ to dummy's ♥Q. East shows out. Play dummy's last ♠. West is now void, so if he ruffs you over-ruff. Otherwise you ruff with a small trump.

You are back in your hand.

Now throw East in (you hope!) with the ♣10.

Fortunately East has to take the ♣10. Since he has nothing left but ♣s and ♦s he must lead one or the other. A ♦ lead will give you a trick with your ♦K and a ♣ lead will allow you to ruff in dummy (West still has a ♣) and discard a ♦ from your hand.

Some problems are tougher than others, this being a tough one.

It was not a complete elimination since West still had a trump when you threw East in. However, it worked because East was out of both ♠s and ♥s.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 8 ♥ Q 10 8 4 2 ♦ A 9 5 2 ♣ A J 8	
♠ J 10 9 7 5 ♥ 7 ♦ K 8 6 3 ♣ K 5 3		♠ A K Q 6 3 2 ♥ A 6 3 ♦ 7 ♣ 7 6 4
	♠ 4 ♥ K J 9 5 ♦ Q J 10 4 ♣ Q 10 9 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♦Q

East is to play 4♠. South leads the ♦Q.

North plays the ♦2 and you the ♦7.

South continues with the ♦J.

North plays low and you ruff with the ♠Q.

Unless South is real beginner North will hold the ♦A so you should not try the ♦K on this trick. And when South continues with the ♦J you should again duck in dummy, ruffing with an honor in your hand.

The contract is in danger if North holds the ♣A because you would have three ♣ losers to go with the ♦ already lost. One really good possibility is that North now has the lone ♦A and you can set up dummy's ♦K with a ruff.

So play a small ♠ to dummy's ♠9, (pulling the two outstanding trumps), and ruff another ♦ with an honor, hoping the ♦A drops.

Too bad, the ♦A did not fall so dummy's ♦K is not a winner. But it will still prove to be useful.

Play the ♥A, then ruff a ♥ in dummy. Play a trump to your ♠A and ruff your last ♥.

You are in dummy, just where you want to be.

North plays the ♦A.

Play the ♦K, and when North plays the ♦A don't ruff but instead discard a ♣ from your hand. You knew all along that he held the ♦A.

North is end-played, forced to either break the ♣s and give you a ♣ trick, or give you a ruff-sluff.

This was the toughest hand so far and the end-play depended upon your correct reading that North must hold the ♦A.

It also depended upon the defenders not switching to ♣s at the second trick. If South had decided to switch to the ♣Q you would have had no chance at all.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 7 6
♥ K J 7 2
♦ A K 6 4
♣ 10 8 3

♠ Q 10 8 5 2
♥ 6
♦ Q 9 7
♣ K Q 5 2



♠ K 9 4 3
♥ 8 5
♦ 10 8 5 3 2
♣ 7 6

♠ A J
♥ A Q 10 9 4 3
♦ J
♣ A J 9 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	3♥	Pass	6♥
All Pass			

6♥ by South
Lead: ♠5

After hearing a limit raise, South's leap to 6♥ is, well, bold let's say. South plays 6♥. West leads the ♠5, dummy plays the ♠6 and East the ♠K.

Dummy wins the ♦K.

Dummy leads the ♦A and East follows.

Very bold in fact. The opening lead has exposed a ♠ loser in addition to your two ♣ losers. On the plus side dummy has an extra ♦ trick. You are going to have to try to throw West in with the ♣ suit, but you will have to be very careful with dummy's entries.

Win the ♠A, play the ♦J to dummy's ♦K and discard the ♠J on dummy's ♦A.

You are in dummy, so ruff the ♠7 with a high trump. Next play the ♥9 to dummy's ♥J. Both defenders follow, whew!

Back in dummy, ruff a ♦ with the ♥Q, then lead the ♥10 to dummy's ♥K, pulling the last trump as you enter dummy.

It would be great if you could ruff dummy's last ♦, then get back to dummy with a trump so you could lead a ♣ from dummy and finesse. But check your trumps. If you do that you will have no more trumps in your hand and West won't be endplayed because you have no ruff-sluff. The only thing you can do is to go ahead and play ♣s now, finessing into West and HOPING he has no more ♦s!

You were lucky, West had only three ♦s so your partial elimination worked.

But if it had turned out that West DID have another ♦, and led it, all would not be lost. You would ruff in your hand, play a trump to dummy, then take a second ♣ finesse. If it turned out the ♣K and ♣Q were in different hands you would make the slam.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K J 10 8 6 5 3 ♥ 10 5 ♦ J 10 8 ♣ 3	
♠ Q 9 4 ♥ A 9 6 ♦ A K Q ♣ A Q 5 4		♠ A 7 2 ♥ K Q J ♦ 7 5 2 ♣ K J 6 2
	♠ — ♥ 8 7 4 3 2 ♦ 9 6 4 3 ♣ 10 9 8 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2NT	3♠	6NT	
All Pass			

6NT by West
Lead: ♦J

Some bidding, huh? Well, what would you have bid in the East seat? West plays 6NT. North leads the ♦J.

Mirror distributions! So you can only make ten tricks in ♥s, ♦s and ♣s.

That means you will have to make two ♠ tricks. And since the odds are 5000 to 1 that North has the ♠K, leading toward your ♠Q is NOT your play.

Win the ♦ and play 4 rounds of ♣s. North follows to the first, then discards 3 ♠s.

Next play 3 ♥ winners. North follows twice, then discards a ♠.

Now play your 2 ♦ winners. South and North both follow.

Keeping your fingers crossed that North must win the next trick,

North puts on the ♠10.

South (thankfully) discards a ♥.

North has been thrown in and he has nothing left but the ♠ K J. Whichever one he plays you will take the last two tricks.

North no doubt thought his 3♠ bid was a good idea.

In fact, it just kept you from making a losing play, (leading toward the ♠Q), and allowed you to find the end-play to make the slam.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 8 5 ♥ A K 10 5 ♦ K 7 2 ♣ K 7 4	
♠ A Q J 10 9 4 ♥ 7 2 ♦ Q 8 ♣ J 6 5	N W E S	♠ 6 ♥ 9 4 3 ♦ J 10 9 6 ♣ Q 10 8 3 2
	♠ 7 3 2 ♥ Q J 8 6 ♦ A 5 4 3 ♣ A 9	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
2♠	3♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠6

North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♠6, taken by West with the ♠A. West returns the ♠Q, you play the ♠K and East ruffs. East next leads the ♦J.

After that unfortunate start you seem to be in a bit of trouble. Two tricks are already in the defender's pockets and you still have a ♠ loser and a ♦ loser. So you win with your ♦K and play two rounds of trumps.

The good news is that East started with three trumps, and since he already used one it only takes two pulls to pick up the remaining trumps.

Eliminate ♣s by playing ♣A, ♣K, and ruffing a ♣. Both defenders follow to all three ♣s.

So far West has followed suit to every trick, meaning he has not discarded a single ♠. Since you know he started with 6 ♠s, his final 5 cards consist of 4 ♠s and one other. You play to the ♦A and West follows suit again.

Dummy's ♠7: West wins, but he has nothing left but ♠s. When he plays another ♠ you discard your ♦ loser and ruff in dummy.

This is called a Partial Elimination because all of the ♦s were not eliminated.

However, the key is that you could tell they were eliminated from the West hand, and West was going to be the throw-in target because of his long ♠s.

In many hands an opponent who opens with a preemptive bid gives you the information you need to plan and execute the throw-in.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 8 4 ♥ J 10 8 ♦ J 10 8 5 4 ♣ A 9 3	
♠ A J 9 6 5 3 ♥ 5 2 ♦ A 2 ♣ 8 7 6	N W E S	♠ K Q 10 2 ♥ A Q 6 4 ♦ Q 7 ♣ Q J 4
	♠ 7 ♥ K 9 7 3 ♦ K 9 6 3 ♣ K 10 5 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♥	Pass	2♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♣2

West first transfers you to ♠s, then closes the auction with 4♠.

East is to play 4♠. South leads the ♣2. North takes the ♣A and returns the ♣9 to South's ♣K. South plays another ♣ to your ♣Q.

With two tricks lost already you have a sure ♦ loser (unless the defenders goof) and a ♥ loser that might be taken care of if North holds the ♥K. But what if South holds the ♥K? Maybe an elimination play.

First pull trumps - they split 2-1.

Next eliminate ♦s by playing ♦A then another ♦. This does the elimination and throw-in at the same time.

If the defender who won the ♦K plays a ♦ or a ♣ you will ruff in your hand and discard dummy's ♥ loser. So that defender is going to have to lead a ♥.

If it is South who won the ♦K you are home free. His ♥ play will give you two ♥ tricks.

If it is North who won the ♦K you still have a chance. He will lead a ♥ and you will finesse the ♥Q.

In other words, played this way you make the contract whenever South holds the ♦K **OR** North holds the ♥K.

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With the cards as shown the elimination play works.

But if the ♦K is with North and the ♥K with South it wouldn't.

Of course it is POSSIBLE that if you played a low ♦ from dummy some Easts would duck and let you win a trick with your ♦Q.

This trickery would fail if South held the ♦K, or if North held it and went up right away.